and size, and where India's land mass fit into it. [1] This supercontinent broke up around 750 million years ago and the various continents began to drift apart. Very little is known about this period (loosely dubbed the Pre-Cambrian period). Existing life forms were no more than single-cell organisms like bacteria. However, there is one remaining relic from the Pre-Cambrian period that is still very visible—the Aravalli range. It is arguably the oldest surviving geological feature anywhere in the world.

The Aravallis were once tall mountains, possibly as high as the Himalayas. Over hundreds of millions of years they have been eroded down to low hills and ridges. Yet, these diminutive hills have been witness to many important events of Indian history. The northernmost point of the Aravallis is the North Ridge near Delhi University. Today, college sweethearts cuddle among the ancient rocks, oblivious to both passers-by and history, but the North Ridge was the stage for an important turning point in Indian history. It was here that a small British garrison held out in 1857 against a much larger force of Indian rebels and pounded the walls of Shahjehanabad (what is now called Old Delhi). The British eventually received reinforcements and stormed the city. Mughal emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar was exiled to Burma and his sons were executed. Thus ended the great Mughal dynasty. [2]

From Delhi, the Aravallis extend into Haryana. As I write, I can see the low rocky ridges holding out against an onslaught of Gurgaon's modern buildings. Sadly these ancient hills are now being destroyed by indiscriminate mining. One of the worst examples of this can be seen on a side branch of the range near Jodhpur, Rajasthan. Ask to be driven to Balsamand Lake, an eleventh-century lake on the outskirts of the city. The lake is often dry these days due to the wholesale destruction of its water-catchment area. [3] Along its banks is an area of several square kilometres where the terrain has been gouged out by stone quarrying (some legal, some illegal). The air is filled with the sound of drills and dynamite, the dust and smoke of trucks laden with stone. Not a single tree stands against the glare of the relentless desert sun. It is a vision of hell.